



Sinopharm gets WHO approval

Sinopharm, the Chinese state-owned company has got the WHO's approval for its vaccine.
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Chernobyl smoldering

Nuclear reactions are smoldering again at Chernobyl and has scientists worried.
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Apple AirTags

₹3k to track my wallet which contains less money than that?

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Why is it that I end up having to boo so many Apple products? I'm not anti-Apple, I'm anti-everything, so why do Apple products find their way into these columns I write so often? I think it's because of how popular they are. Apple releases make a noise like no other company's products do when they hit the market, and that forces us to take notice, which then makes my editor force me to write a column about them. Anyway, enough booing my editor, time to boo yet another Apple device.

For those who have been living under a rock, Apple announced their AirTags at an event in late April, along with the new M1 powered Macs and the iPad Pro. The Apple AirTag is an electronic tag that you can attach to a device or object that you tend to misplace around your house, and it then uses your iPhone to pair with and track it. You use Apple's Find My network to do this, and if you're within Bluetooth range of the lost item, you can even instruct your AirTag to play a sound so that you can follow the sound to find the missing item.

It's barely been released and people are already trying to find creative uses for these AirTags, including trying to use them as trackers for pets. Initial results show that they're not best suited for objects like pets that move about themselves, and

are ideally designed for inanimate objects like phones, wallets, purses, backpacks, etc.

It doesn't only work in our houses, because AirTags can be identified and tracked using the Find My network. This means that if you have an iPhone that has its Bluetooth and Find My network turned on, and are sitting, say, in a train, next to the backpack I lost, your phone will report the backpack to the Find My network. This only works if I have reported the tag associated with my backpack as lost, so it's not going to pick up every AirTag in the vicinity. Of course, Apple says it cares about privacy, so no one will know that it is your phone reporting the location of my backpack, because they say that Find My network tracks objects not people.

Is this idea Apple's? Obviously not. The idea itself is old, and Tile is probably the company that made it popular enough to get noticed by Apple. In fact, the Tile network does exactly what Apple's Find My network does, except that Tile's network isn't as vast as Apple's, obviously.

So far so good. Why am I even booing this? Apart from the price of over ₹3k for a tag, and a strap costing extra, is price my only complaint? If rich people want to waste money on showing off by pinging their lost stuff, it doesn't concern me. What is obvious to me immediately is that this is not really going to work that well in India. iPhones aren't as ubiquitous in India as they are in some other countries. Your lost backpack is not really going to be found by a network once you leave it on a bus or train. It will be found by a person, and whether you get it back

or not depends solely on the person who found it and the value of what you have inside the backpack. Given that Apple products are quite the craze, it's even possible that objects with AirTags will be stolen... for the AirTags themselves! Or else you will find someone cutting the AirTag off your backpack in a crowded bus or train. Overall, this seems like something those with their own cars and drivers would want more, or those who want to track things in their homes.



Given that the average home isn't really massive in India, this product seems very niche to me from an Indian perspective.

That's not my only problem with AirTags though. Tile has accused Apple of being anti-competitive, and even testified in antitrust hearings against Apple. And I have to say, they have a very valid case. What Apple has done is give Tile and other such service providers less access to the iOS system than their own AirTags get. This is inherently unfair, as it means that no product can ever compete with AirTags on an Apple ecosystem. Allowing Apple to do this would result in Apple being able to replicate a good business idea that someone else had, and kill it off by giving their own products features that no one else could access.

And it gets worse for AirTags, as they were pulled off shelves in retailers across Australia, because the country has very strict laws about child safety, and AirTags have removable batteries that are deemed a choking hazard for small children and pets. The one time Apple adds a user replaceable battery to a product, and it gets called out for doing it! 🚫